

PTI

Sporting Spirit

A world champion and multiple Asian Games gold medallist in compound archery, Ojas Pravin Deotale exercises his right to vote for the first time on April 19. "My parents told me every vote matters, so regardless of whom one votes for, one should," he says. He may be a newbie to the process but he's not naive—he relies on factors like delivering on promises made and development in sports to cast his vote.

OJAS PRAVIN DEOTALE, 21

International archer

Lok Sabha constituency: Nagpur, Maharashtra

Top 3 demands: More sports infra at grassroots level, strict implementation of environmental laws, affordable education for underprivileged kids

What will influence his vote: Delivering on promises made, development of sports, India's image in the world, progress through new technology

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Life as a full-time archer means the undergraduate doesn't have time to dig deep into politics but he says he tries to keep up with political developments and government schemes. India's rising stature in sports—he cites the performance at the 2023 Asian Games in Hangzhou which saw the nation cross the 100-medal mark, to which Deotale contributed three golds—and increased investment in it are a matter of great pride for him. "Earlier, we wouldn't get many medals, but now you can see the results," he says. Deotale suggests development of "sports parks" across the country where kids can play and adults exercise to build a passion for all sports. ■

-Suhani Singh



ARABINDA MAHAPATRA

BODHISATTWA SANGHAPRIYA, 28

Founder and CEO, IG Drones, Noida, Uttar Pradesh

Lok Sabha constituency: Bhadrak, Odisha

Thumbs-up to: Education, fairer taxes, Start-up India, Skill India, 'one nation, one election'

Wings to a Dream

Bodhisattwa Sanghapriya was only 22 when he co-founded a drone company along with two of his friends in Odisha's Sambalpur. Started with two clients in 2018, now IG Drones supplies ultra-modern drones to 300-plus clients, including the Indian military.

Bodhisattwa, who holds a B.Tech. degree from Veer Surendra Sai University of Technology, Burla, in Sambalpur, believes voting is everyone's responsibility. While applauding the Modi government's policies in the past 10 years, he commends the Startup India initiative that supports over 100,000 startups. "Moreover, their skill mission, advocating digitisation and inclusive development nationwide, are truly laudable," he says. And, Bodhisattwa feels the One Nation, One Election proposal, if implemented, will streamline the electoral process, reducing administrative burden, thereby promoting efficiency and accountability. As an entrepreneur, Bodhisattwa says he has witnessed a significant shift in India's global perception over the past decade. "Despite challenges like socio-economic disparities, environmental issues and geopolitical tensions, India's image reflects a dynamic mix of progress, potential and continued efforts towards development." ■

"The One Nation, One Election proposal, if implemented, will streamline the electoral process"

-Pradip R. Sagar

A RAINBOW OF RIGHTS

The LGBTQ+ community is largely unhappy about the government's performance vis-a-vis its rights. Most feel that the 2018 decriminalisation of homosexuality by the Supreme Court and the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, are only baby steps, and larger issues have been left unresolved, some being a result of these laws.

For example, the 2019 Act is silent on granting separate reservations in education and employment for the community and criminalises begging without giving an alternative social security. Even more disappointingly, it also disallows provisions for self-determination

